

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Life from Death ~ Heaven & Hell
Eastertide 4

May 18th, 2025



Aurora sul Golfo, 1935 - Gerardo Dottori

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on HYMN TO JOY and LOBE DEN HERREN

ST. COLUMBA (Daniel Burton)

Sólo Tú Eres Santo – QUERÉTARO (George Lachenauer)

Fantasy on SALZBURG (Dennis R. Johnson)

Chorale Prelude on KINGSFOLD (Michael Fontana) and Improvisation

Christ ist erstanden (Johann Kaspar Ferdinand Fischer) and Improvisation

Erschienen ist der herrliche Tag (Johann Gottfried Walther) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Doug Hart & Rev. Fregin

We all breathe.

From that first autonomous act,
to our final letting go,
we breathe our way
through every moment that is our life.

Deeply, as we prepare for enormous effort,
or a short, shallow pant
as we steer a course
through pain and fear,
our inhalations
pace the ecstasies of love,
and the tragedies of loss
binding exhilaration to sorrow
down the thread of our lives.

With our growing awareness,
may we learn to breathe,
not only days
but moments filled with joy.

*And as we do,
may we remember long,
that to breathe is to inspire.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Joyful, Joyful, We Adore You

HYMN TO JOY

Joyful, joyful, we adore you, God of glory, God of love;
Hearts unfold like flowers before you, opening to the sun above.
Melt the clouds of sin and sadness, drive the storms of doubt away;
Giver of immortal gladness, fill us with the light of day.
All your works with joy surround you, earth and heaven reflect your rays,
Stars and angels sing around you, center of unbroken praise.
Field and forest, vale and mountain, flowery meadow, flashing sea,
Chanting bird and flowing fountain teach us what our praise should be.

You are giving and forgiving, ever blessing, ever blessed,
Well-spring of the joy of living, ocean depth of happy rest!
Loving Spirit, Father, Mother, all who love belong to you;
Teach us how to love each other, by that love our joy renew.

Mortals, join the mighty chorus, which the morning stars began;
God's own love is reigning o'er us, joining people hand in hand
Ever singing, march we onward, victors in the midst of strife;
Joyful music leads us sunward in the triumph song of life.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Eternal One,
could we but find you in the sky,
our eyes would never leave the heavens.
Could we but feel you in a brook,
the wetness of the water would become our longing.
Could we but know you in your words
all secrets told as we long to hear
your song of the ages.

On this day,
Come unto us, O Holiness and Wonder,
come unto us,
that we might see the fullness of your dream,
in all its beauty and might.

Come unto us,
so that our hearts can rest as we continue to seek you.
And let us be safe and secure in your depths...
for they are also our mystery to see and to know.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Good Morning Merry Sunshine"
Frank Hobbs, Guitar and Voice

TRADITIONAL LULLABY
FROM NORTH AMERICA

***The Lord's Prayer**

Doug Hart

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people.
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!*

[John Philip Newell]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

We come from God
and in a breath,
life comes to us,
drawing into us the world
and all we will know, experience, and love.

And in a breath, life leaves us,
our hopes, dreams, possibilities
exhaled into a vast eternity
as we return to God.

In-between,
we ask for the wisdom to
breathe deep the residue of what has been,
to breathe deep the essence of what now is,
and to breathe deep the elements coalescing into what will be.

We ask for the wisdom to know
all that resides within us,
all that is folded into us through the living we have done,
animating us in this moment of awareness,
and lifting us toward tomorrow's light.

On this day,
*Remind us to breathe deep all of who we are and have been.
Remind us to breathe into all that we may become.
Remind us to breathe as those whose breathe
still calls us to tomorrow.*

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Welcoming New Members

Rev. Lehman

*Dan Akira Nishimura
Matt Ambrose
Velma Campbell
Cliff Cogger
Victoria Holladay
JR Houska
Katherine Koh
Lolly Lim
Melissa Lo
Matt Warburton*

Beloved friends, we gather as one, woven together by the threads of love, justice, peace, and hope. Today, we are overjoyed to welcome these new members into our sacred community:
With open hearts and joyful spirits, we welcome you!

Each of you brings your unique story, faith, experience, insights, questions, enthusiasm, and gifts. Already, you are a blessing to all of us.
Together, we will welcome and celebrate your gifts, as we deepen our spiritual journeys, build community, and work for justice.

May you always find this community a place of belonging and acceptance, where you are known and cherished exactly as you are.
We promise to welcome and celebrate the fullness of who you are, and journey with you, celebrating your joys, and accompanying you in your struggles.

In the spirit of Christ's radical welcome, we say:
*Welcome to the table of love. Welcome to the work of peace. Welcome to the church.
You are home.*

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
from the First Epistle of John

Doug Hart

This is the Gospel of Grace and Love.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People
Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Rev. Fregin

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

In stillness we open our hearts
to the whisper of your Holiness, O God.
Chords of music
fill us with deep reverence
for the wonders we see and know in creation.

The rhythms of life come constant to us
through the blessing of music
and steady our pulse.

This morning, Holy One, let us overflow with
the gifts of past and present
and feel the sacred in each note,
each chord,
each harmony of life.

*We ask this as those who long
to experience your heaven
in the here and now.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

"Good Morning"
Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

TARA MACK

Sermon

Heaven & Hell

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Bridge Over Troubled Water"
Frank Hobbs, *Vocalist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Collaborative Pianist*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

PAUL SIMON, arr. KIRBY SHAW

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Doug Hart

Enveloping Wisdom of Grace,
with our offerings we thank you for this priceless day,
which will never come again.
Through it, you offer us
the opportunity to fill it with compassion and joy.

Help us to trust in your unfolding grace
and transcend self-concern,
so that at this very moment, and throughout this day,
we may live fearlessly and generate lovingkindness,
and thereby experience the only true wealth:
that of life in you.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Infinite Reality,
Unending in time,
Unending in every direction,
You surround us,
You pervade us.

Everywhere we look,
There you are.
We swim in a sea that is made of you.

And then, Holy One,
lift concern from our hearts,
For we are filled with your being.
Give us an awareness that always and forever,
We rest in you,
Both now, and forever more.

[adpt/johnmccquiston]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Lift Thine Eyes" from *Elijah*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

FELIX MENDELSSOHN

***Hymn for the Journey**

Sing Praise

LOBE DEN HERREN

Sing praise to all that has offered us life and sustains us –
All that has opened our hearts to the love borne within us:
Family and friends,
Beauty we see without end –
Gifts that our lives lay before us.

Sing praise to all that has opened our minds to new vistas –
All that has called us to seek out new truths through the ages:
Vision and word,
Music that sought to be heard
These are the gifts that will mold us.

Sing praise to minds that will fashion our bold new tomorrows –
Yesterday's wisdom released from its dogma and credos.
Evermore free
To live out what we believe
Walking the path that life hallows.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Short Fugue in G Major (ascribed to J.S. Bach)

Inside The Music

"Our music today explores the idea of Heaven on Earth. We begin with a traditional lullaby which follows a child asking the Sun where it goes at night. The sun replies that it never sets nor goes away, instead, it travels to the children of the East who also seek its light. We first hear this poem at the introit through the simplicity of solo voice and guitar, and we hear it next in meditation through choral polyphony. In this natural progression of aural texture, we imagine the growing complexity within the mind of a child, remaining open within and despite its intellectual deepening. In her performance note for *Good Morning*, composer Tara Mack writes that *"the overall effect should be to remind both performer and listener of that moment in their lives when they believed it was possible to have a conversation with the sun."* The Sun, available to all across the globe, its light given daily and without expectation of acknowledged receipt, is a reminder of God's grace freely given.

In offertory we sing Paul Simon's illustration of the Beloved Community where, indeed, we have the potential to bring Heaven to our Here and Now. Through despair or flood, weariness or tears, it is the nourishing and cultivating of our relationships with one another that affirm life!

And finally, in choral response, we sing Felix Mendelssohn's setting of Psalm 121 which maintains the text of our opening lullaby. Indeed, the merry sunshine never sets, *God neither slumbers nor sleeps*, but remains ever present in the Nature around us, encouraging us to *lift our eyes to the mountains, from whence cometh God's help*. We see, then, that through Nature, through child-like wonder, through Relationship and Community, the Divine Flow of God helps us appreciate that we, together, have the capacity to either nurture or disturb Heaven on Earth." -Dr. Ianthe Marini